central leadership may adopt the Assam model in Manipur. In the Assam polls last year, the party did not name any chief ministerial candidate. After victory, incumbent Sarbananda Sonowal was replaced by Himanta Biswa Sarma, an import from the Congress who made no secret of his chief ministerial ambitions. The BJP's slogan in Manipur is to cross the 40-seat mark (from 21 in 2017). If Biren Singh's chief ministership can earn the party a majority, it will be very difficult to dethrone him.

## WHO WILL PLAY KINGMAKER?

Biren Singh faces resistance from the NPP—whose party leader and deputy chief minister Yumnam Joykumar Singh has been a vocal critic of the CM. "NPP members were appointed ministers but not allowed to function," alleges Joykumar Singh. In 2020, Biren Singh's government had almost collapsed when four NPP MLAs withdrew support. Long negotiations and the BJP central leadership's intervention helped end the crisis, with the four NPP leaders returning to the fold.

Should the BJP need the NPP's support to attain a majority, the Shillong-headquartered party may demand Biren's replacement. Observers do not rule out the NPP even claiming the CM's post. "We have grown in size and acceptance among the people over the past five years. We are confident of emerging as the single largest party," says Joykumar Singh, even though his party is contesting only 40 seats. NPP national president and Meghalaya chief minister Conrad Sangma offers a more reasonable assessment—a double digit tally for the NPP, as against four in 2017.

Independent observers concur that the NPP will certainly emerge bigger in the election, at the cost of both the BJP and Congress. "The NPP has selected better candidates than other parties. In Manipur, the track record of the candidate plays a bigger role than of the party," says Laishram of Manipur University. The NPP claims it is finding traction among young voters through a carefully crafted digital campaign monitored by Joykumar Singh's daughter Ratika Yumnam, an Oxford graduate. As head of the NPP youth wing, she is seen as the new-age face of the party. "People are connecting with us because of our northeast ideology. While we represent the unique local culture and local issues, the BJP lacks touch with the grassroots," says Ratika.

A formidable electoral plank for the NPP is the demand for the repeal of the contentious Armed Forces (Special Powers) Act, or AFSPA. Between 2012 and 2016, 186 cases of human rights violations by security forces were recorded in states where AFSPA is in force. Manipur accounted for 11 per cent of the cases. In 2016, the Supreme Court, while hearing a case on extra-judicial killings in Manipur, asserted that AFSPA did not guarantee blanket impunity to the armed forces. Ironically, there have been allegations of fake encounters against Joykumar Singh, who was Manipur DGP between 2007 and 2012. He refutes the charges.

The repeal of AFSPA finds place in the Congress manifesto as well. Cornered, Biren Singh claims he is committed to repealing the draconian act. But for that to happen, his government wants to create a conducive environment first. The killing of an army colonel and his family in an ambush by militants in the state's Churachandpur district in November last year—the first such strike since 2015—had provided the BJP government an argument in favour of continuing with AFSPA.

One achievement the BJP can flaunt is the introduction of Inner Line Permit (ILP) in Manipur 2019. This was a longstanding demand in the state. Several northeastern states, such as Arunachal Pradesh, Nagaland and Mizoram, also require non-resident citizens to obtain limited-duration ILP permits for travel within the state. The system was introduced to protect ethnic identity and culture. But beyond these identity issues, the people of Manipur want development, jobs and lasting peace. Given the heavy dependence on central grants, the state has often voted for the party in power in Delhi. In that sense, the BJP may hold an edge, but elections in this border state have never been linear or predictable. It may be no different this time. ■




ANI

**OLD WARHORSE**
Congress leader Okram Ibobi Singh in Delhi

## CONGRESS

*CM contender*
**Okram Ibobi Singh, 73**

***Alliance partners:*** **Five Left parties though there are some friendly contests**

### STRENGTHS

- Acceptance among both Hindu and Christian voters
- NPP's emergence may cut into BJP votes
- Anti-incumbency against BJP due to lack of jobs and poor infrastructure

### CHALLENGES

- Deep factionalism within the party
- Several winnable candidates defected to BJP
- Unable to match BJP's financial might